the Muslims...and present-day Muslims can't be held responsible for the conduct of those who lived 500 years back."

In her defence, Nupur said her comments had been in response to "insults" made against Lord Shiva, while Jindal quietly deleted his offensive tweets. But the damage had already been done. Kanpur witnessed violent protests and a subsequent police crackdown, in which 12 people were arrested on June 7. BJP Yuva Morcha leader Harshit Srivastava Lala was among those held, again reportedly for tweets and other messages related to the Prophet.

But it was the international reaction, especially in the Gulf countries, that put the party in deep embarrassment. All the more acutely because vice-president M. Venkaiah Naidu was just then on an official trip to Qatar to discuss modalities to celebrate 50 years of diplomatic ties. Social media spaces in the Arab world were flooded with messages about boycotting Indian products, rejecting our human resources etc., all citing Nupur's comments. The V-P's lunch meeting with the deputy emir was cancelled at the last minute on Saturday, citing "medical reasons". Fearing a media blowback, New Delhi, too, cancelled Naidu's scheduled press conference in Qatar.

On Sunday, June 5, Qatar foreign minister Sultan bin Saad Al-Muraikhi summoned Indian ambassador Deepak Mittal to hand over an official note, expressing "disappointment of the state of Qatar and its total rejection and condemnation of the controversial remarks made by an official in the ruling party in India against Prophet Muhammad". As the news spread, other countries in West Asia such as Iran, Saudi Arabia and Kuwait also summoned the Indian envoys there to express their displeasure. Soon, the OIC (Organisation of Islamic Cooperation), Pakistan, Indonesia and other Muslim countries were joining in the condemnation.

For India, West Asia and especially the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries are important trading partners. India is dependent on them for over 40 per cent of its energy requirements, while more than 5.9 million Indians work in these countries, sending home billions in foreign remittances. With GCC countries alone, India has trade of more than $155 billion.



The BJP-RSS have the delicate task of trying to curb fringe elements, within the party or outside, from taking over the Hindutva mantle

In the past eight years, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has invested heavily in building relations with these countries.

Senior BJP leaders claim the statements of the offending leaders were in contravention of the stated party line. "Spokespersons attend TV debates as representatives of the ruling party... there are strings attached to this privilege. One can't get carried away," says a top leader. Critics, though, say that, for too long, the party has given a long rope to office-bearers and serial offenders like Nupur. Party sources claim the timing of the incident is unfortunate, for the BJP and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) have been trying to curb the fringe elements—within the party or outside—from taking over the Hindutva debate. They say with Modi getting political points for the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya and the Yogi Adityanath government getting a second term in Uttar Pradesh, the party was in the driver's seat to carry forward the larger Hindutva agenda. Indeed, the BJP-ruled states had started highlighting contentious issues like uniform civil code, anti-conversion laws etc. again.

The BJP is now toeing the Hindutva line cautiously. The party image has taken a beating internationally, and domestically it has no standing with the Muslim community. Indeed, after the retirement of cabinet minister Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi, editor-turned-neta M.J. Akbar and spokesperson Syed Zafar Islam from the Rajya Sabha, the party will not have any Muslim representation in Parliament.

The party and RSS leadership are also taking a restrained stand in the ongoing controversy related to the mosques at Mathura's Krishna Janmabhoomi and Varanasi's Gyanvapi. On June 2, speaking at an RSS training programme in Nagpur, *sarsanghchalak* Mohan Bhagwat said, "History cannot be disputed. Several temples were desecrated by Islamic invaders...issues have only been raised on places over which Hindus have a special devotion". That said, he added that "if the issue goes to court, its decision should be acceptable to both sides". BJP president J.P. Nadda echoed the sentiment at a press meet in Delhi: "The court and Constitution will decide (the disputes) and the BJP will follow their verdict in letter and spirit."

On the ground, the heat isn't letting up. Al Qaeda has sent out suicide bomber threats, Delhi Police has beefed up security for Nupur after she alleged death threats, and in UP, the Yogi regime is back with the bulldozer and a list of 40 rioters in Kanpur. The Centre has to navigate these troubled waters while restoring calm all around. ■